Strixhaven: School of Mages Report: Learned Archetypes, Bombs, and Synergies

MTGNET

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Dataset Snapshot

This run on Strixhaven: School of Mages uses 101,865 unique deck builds and 465,319 game rows. The unsupervised clustering stage produced 5 learned archetypes. Card win rates are games-in-hand (GIH) win rates; an archetype's win rate is over all of its games. The best-performing large shells are Orzhov | Silverquill Pledgemage / Guiding Voice, Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip, Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage, which already tells us that the format is not a single monolithic color table: it separates into distinct deck families with their own signposts, core cards, and standalone bombs.

How to Read This Report

- **Coreness** measures how central a card is to an archetype: played in many of its decks, characteristic of it, and connected to the rest of the deck. Cards are grouped into Core, Support and Periphery rings. A core card may carry a tag: **signature** (in bold: played in at least 15% of this archetype's decks and in at most one other archetype at that rate) or *staple* (at least 25% of this archetype's decks and at least 15% in three or more archetypes); untagged core cards are neither.
- **Play rate** is the share of the archetype's decks that play at least one copy.
- **Bombs** are cards that are strong on their own. A bomb's **lift** compares, within the decks that play it, the win rate when the card is in hand with the win rate when it stayed in the library, relative to a typical card of the archetype, and is shrunk across archetypes; it is shown in percentage points (pp). Bombs are listed whatever ring they sit in: core and support bombs keep their ring on the site, and only bombs that would otherwise be peripheral go to the bomb island beside the rings.
- A **synergy pair** wins more often when both cards are drawn than their separate effects predict (games-in-hand, adjusted for game length and play/draw). The effect λ is an interaction log-odds, shown as a percentage change in the odds of winning with its 95% confidence interval. Pairs are tested with Benjamini–Hochberg false-discovery control: *verified* means $q \leq 0.10$, *tentative* means $q \leq 0.25$. Few pairs pass; an absent pair means "not detectable with this data", not "no synergy".

- **Payoff** and **engine** roles are decided by synergy arrows only: the synergy pairs (verified or tentative) whose direction is significant. In such a pair the arrow points from the payoff, the card that wins more when drawn without its partner, to the engine it rewards; a card whose arrows mostly point out of it is a payoff, one whose arrows mostly point into it an engine. The arrow reflects each card's standalone strength within the pair, not a direction of the synergy itself. Played-together links carry the same arrow on the site as context only; they do not set roles.

1 Discovered Archetypes

Archetype	Decks	Games	WR	Top signposts
Orzhov | Silverquill Pledgemage / Guiding Voice	20,573	98,065	57.48%	Silverquill Pledgemage, Guiding Voice, Arrogant Poet, Owlin Shieldmage, Combat Professor
Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	25,079	116,194	55.04%	Eureka Moment, Field Trip, Needlethorn Drake, Leyline Invocation, Scurrid Colony
Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	15,434	68,082	53.64%	Illustrious Historian, Lorehold Pledgemage, Enthusiastic Study, Pilgrim of the Ages, Combat Professor
Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	17,771	79,250	53.01%	Hunt for Specimens, Blood Researcher, Witherbloom Pledgemage, Bayou Groff, Professor of Zoomancy
Izzet | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	23,008	103,728	52.96%	Prismari Pledgemage, Elemental Masterpiece, Spectacle Mage, Pigment Storm, Heated Debate

2 Core of Each Archetype

The core ring of each archetype, most central first, with the share of the archetype's decks that play each card and its tag where it has one: **signature** (in bold) or staple. The second line lists the archetype's bombs, whatever ring they sit in: cards that are strong on their own, with their lift (in-hand vs in-library win rate within the decks that play them, relative to a typical card of the archetype, shrunk across archetypes) and their games in hand.

Archetype	Core cards (play rate)
Simic 25,079 decks	**Needlethorn Drake** (59%, signature), **Field Trip** (57%, signature), **Eureka Moment** (63%, signature), **Biomathematician** (44%, signature), **Scurrid Colony** (48%, signature), **Leyline Invocation** (48%, signature), Quandrix Pledgemage (49%, staple), **Mage Duel** (52%, signature), **Decisive Denial** (31%, signature), **Bury in Books** (55%, signature) *Bombs:* Magma Opus (+13.2 pp, 1,736 games); Multiple Choice (+9.8 pp, 5,012 games); Crackle with Power (+9.0 pp, 762 games); Poet's Quill (+8.8 pp, 1,082 games)
Izzet 23,008 decks	**Spectacle Mage** (64%, signature), **Prismari Pledgemage** (65%, signature), **Elemental Masterpiece** (62%, signature), **Maelstrom Muse** (37%, signature), **Pigment Storm** (51%, signature), **Pillardrop Warden** (45%, signature), **Creative Outburst** (36%, signature), **Bury in Books** (57%, signature), **Rootha, Mercurial Artist** (42%, signature), **Serpentine Curve** (44%, signature) *Bombs:* Mizzix's Mastery (+13.3 pp, 2,482 games); Velomachus Lorehold (+11.7 pp, 1,486 games); Multiple Choice (+10.4 pp, 4,669 games); Magma Opus (+9.7 pp, 3,103 games)
Orzhov 20,573 decks	**Arrogant Poet** (52%, signature), **Owlin Shieldmage** (56%, signature), **Guiding Voice** (57%, signature), **Spiteful Squad** (48%, signature), **Killian, Ink Duelist** (40%, signature), **Study Break** (48%, signature), Silverquill Pledgemage (57%, staple), **Silverquill Apprentice** (34%, signature), **Star Pupil** (36%, signature), **Exhilarating Elocution** (26%, signature) *Bombs:* Blot Out the Sky (+12.5 pp, 2,038 games); Velomachus Lorehold (+10.7 pp, 586 games); Shadrix Silverquill (+10.3 pp, 2,214 games); Sedgemoor Witch (+9.0 pp, 3,051 games)
Golgari 17,771 decks	**Blood Researcher** (64%, signature), **Infuse with Vitality** (46%, signature), **Bayou Groff** (43%, signature), **Hunt for Specimens** (60%, signature), **Dina, Soul Steeper** (35%, signature), **Witherbloom Pledgemage** (51%, signature), **Moldering Karok** (45%, signature), **Witherbloom Apprentice** (35%, signature), **Professor of Zoomancy** (50%, signature), **Unwilling Ingredient** (39%, signature) *Bombs:* Blot Out the Sky (+11.5 pp, 919 games); Poet's Quill (+9.8 pp, 3,421 games); Shadrix Silverquill (+9.3 pp, 717 games); Multiple Choice (+9.0 pp, 623 games)
Boros Spirits 15,434 decks	**Stonebound Mentor** (56%, signature), **Illustrious Historian** (57%, signature), **Quintorius, Field Historian** (38%, signature), **Pilgrim of the Ages** (52%, signature), **Lorehold Pledgemage** (53%, signature), **Blood Age General** (41%, signature), **Tome Shredder** (44%, signature), **Fuming Effigy** (36%, signature), **Enthusiastic Study** (49%, signature), **Stonerise Spirit** (39%, signature) *Bombs:* Lorehold Command (+13.8 pp, 4,278 games); Magma Opus (+13.0 pp, 326 games); Blot Out the Sky (+11.7 pp, 636 games); Day of Judgment (+10.3 pp, 774 games)

3 What Defines the Best Shells

Orzhov | Silverquill Pledgemage / Guiding Voice

This cluster contains 20,573 decks across 98,065 games and posts a baseline win rate of 57.48%. Its core (the cards most central to it) is `Arrogant Poet` (52% of decks), `Owlin Shieldmage` (56% of decks), `Guiding Voice` (57% of decks), `Spiteful Squad` (48% of decks), `Killian, Ink Duelist` (40% of decks). Its defining signposts are `Silverquill Pledgemage`, `Guiding Voice`, `Arrogant Poet`, `Owlin Shieldmage`, `Combat Professor`, `Lash of Malice`.

Bombs that win on their own here: `Blot Out the Sky` (+12.5 pp), `Velomachus Lorehold` (+10.7 pp), `Shadrix Silverquill` (+10.3 pp). Out of 496 card pairs tested, 4 are verified synergies (BH $q \leq 0.10$) and 4 tentative ($q \leq 0.25$). The strongest verified pair is `Killian, Ink Duelist` + `Rise of Extus`: +20% odds of winning when both are drawn (95% CI [+10, +29]%, 4,565 games). Among its synergy pairs with a significant direction, the payoffs (cards that win more when drawn than their partners) are `Killian, Ink Duelist`, `Arrogant Poet` and the engines they reward are `Exhilarating Elocution`.

Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip

This cluster contains 25,079 decks across 116,194 games and posts a baseline win rate of 55.04%. Its core (the cards most central to it) is `Needlethorn Drake` (59% of decks), `Field Trip` (57% of decks), `Eureka Moment` (63% of decks), `Biomathematician` (44% of decks), `Scurrid Colony` (48% of decks). Its defining signposts are `Eureka Moment`, `Field Trip`, `Needlethorn Drake`, `Leyline Invocation`, `Scurrid Colony`, `Mage Duel`.

Bombs that win on their own here: `Magma Opus` (+13.2 pp), `Multiple Choice` (+9.8 pp), `Crackle with Power` (+9.0 pp). Out of 496 card pairs tested, 3 are verified synergies (BH $q \leq 0.10$) and 3 tentative ($q \leq 0.25$). The strongest verified pair is `Arcane Subtraction` + `Quandrix Pledgemage`: +14% odds of winning when both are drawn (95% CI [+7, +21]%, 8,130 games). Among its synergy pairs with a significant direction, the engines they reward are `Quandrix Pledgemage`.

Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage

This cluster contains 15,434 decks across 68,082 games and posts a baseline win rate of 53.64%. Its core (the cards most central to it) is `Stonebound Mentor` (56% of decks), `Illustrious Historian` (57% of decks), `Quintorius, Field Historian` (38% of decks), `Pilgrim of the Ages` (52% of decks), `Lorehold Pledgemage` (53% of decks). Its defining signposts are `Illustrious Historian`, `Lorehold Pledgemage`, `Enthusiastic Study`, `Pilgrim of the Ages`, `Combat Professor`, `Blood Age General`.

Bombs that win on their own here: `Lorehold Command` (+13.8 pp), `Magma Opus` (+13.0 pp), `Blot Out the Sky` (+11.7 pp). Out of 496 card pairs tested, 7 are verified synergies (BH $q \leq 0.10$) and 10 tentative ($q \leq 0.25$). The strongest verified pair is `Quintorius, Field Historian` + `Tome Shredder`: +25% odds of winning when both are drawn (95% CI [+14, +37]%, 3,278 games). Among its synergy pairs with a significant direction, the payoffs (cards that win more when drawn than their partners) are `Igneous Inspiration`, `Stonerise Spirit` and the engines they reward are `Fuming Effigy`, `Pillardrop Rescuer`.

Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher

This cluster contains 17,771 decks across 79,250 games and posts a baseline win rate of 53.01%. Its core (the cards most central to it) is `Blood Researcher` (64% of decks), `Infuse with Vitality` (46% of decks), `Bayou Groff` (43% of decks), `Hunt for Specimens` (60% of decks), `Dina, Soul Steeper` (35% of decks). Its defining signposts are `Hunt for Specimens`, `Blood Researcher`, `Witherbloom Pledgemage`, `Bayou Groff`, `Professor of Zoomancy`, `Mage Hunters' Onslaught`.

Bombs that win on their own here: `Blot Out the Sky` (+11.5 pp), `Poet's Quill` (+9.8 pp), `Shadrix Silverquill` (+9.3 pp). Out of 496 card pairs tested, 3 are verified synergies (BH $q \leq 0.10$) and 2 tentative ($q \leq 0.25$). The strongest verified pair is `Blood Researcher` + `Overgrown Arch`: +16% odds of winning when both are drawn (95% CI [+7, +26]%, 4,890 games).

4 Bombs: Cards That Are Good Alone

Cards flagged as bombs in at least one archetype, whatever ring they sit in on the site, each shown in the archetype where its lift is largest. *Lift*: within the decks that play the card, the win rate when it is in hand vs when it stayed in the library, relative to a typical card of the archetype, shrunk across archetypes. *Raw lift*: the card's games-in-hand win rate minus the archetype baseline, not shrunk.

Card	Archetype	Lift	Raw lift	GIH WR	Games
`Lorehold Command`	Boros Spirits	+13.8 pp	+11.4 pp	65.03%	4,278
`Mizzix's Mastery`	Izzet	+13.3 pp	+13.4 pp	66.36%	2,482
`Magma Opus`	Simic	+13.2 pp	+12.3 pp	67.34%	1,736
`Blot Out the Sky`	Orzhov	+12.5 pp	+11.8 pp	69.28%	2,038
`Velomachus Lorehold`	Izzet	+11.7 pp	+12.6 pp	65.55%	1,486
`Multiple Choice`	Izzet	+10.4 pp	+12.1 pp	65.11%	4,669
`Shadrix Silverquill`	Orzhov	+10.3 pp	+10.9 pp	68.38%	2,214
`Day of Judgment`	Boros Spirits	+10.3 pp	+9.0 pp	62.66%	774
`Poet's Quill`	Golgari	+9.8 pp	+10.6 pp	63.58%	3,421
`Blade Historian`	Boros Spirits	+9.2 pp	+9.4 pp	63.07%	4,138
`Sedgemoor Witch`	Orzhov	+9.0 pp	+7.6 pp	65.09%	3,051
`Crackle with Power`	Simic	+9.0 pp	+9.5 pp	64.57%	762
`Sparring Regimen`	Orzhov	+8.5 pp	+8.8 pp	66.27%	4,014
`Igneous Inspiration`	Izzet	+8.1 pp	+8.9 pp	61.86%	16,930

5 Build-Arounds and Shell Dependence

Card	Best cluster	Shell dependence	Support delta	Supported games
`Professor's Warning`	Orzhov | Silverquill Pledgemage / Guiding Voice	10.0 / 10	16.39 pp	11465
`Spiteful Squad`	Orzhov | Silverquill Pledgemage / Guiding Voice	10.0 / 10	15.78 pp	22359

Card	Best cluster	Shell dependence	Support delta	Supported games
Serpentine Curve	Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	10.0 / 10	26.74 pp	26016
Quintorius, Field Historian	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	10.0 / 10	23.99 pp	12082
Pillardrop Rescuer	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	10.0 / 10	25.25 pp	13430
Dina, Soul Steeper	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	10.0 / 10	15.39 pp	13646
Blood Researcher	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	9.8 / 10	8.42 pp	30083
Tome Shredder	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	9.6 / 10	19.10 pp	14478
Rise of Extus	Orzhov | Silverquill Pledgemage / Guiding Voice	9.6 / 10	16.22 pp	23245
Pest Summoning	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	9.5 / 10	10.48 pp	23834
Infuriate	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	9.3 / 10	29.54 pp	4314
Witherbloom Pledgemage	Golgari | Hunt for Specimens / Blood Researcher	9.2 / 10	11.64 pp	20919

6 Dependency Cards

Card	Best cluster	Dependency	Standalone lift	Games
Professor's Warning	Orzhov | Silverquill Pledgemage / Guiding Voice	0.365	-1.12 pp	11490
Sedgemoor Witch	Orzhov | Silverquill Pledgemage / Guiding Voice	0.365	7.62 pp	3051
Elemental Masterpiece	Izzet | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	0.292	2.94 pp	38178
Mizzix's Mastery	Izzet | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	0.292	13.39 pp	2482

Card	Best cluster	Dependency	Standalone lift	Games
Pillardrop Rescuer	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	0.281	-2.35 pp	13453
Blade Historian	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	0.281	9.43 pp	4138
Combat Professor	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	0.215	2.81 pp	19429
Infuriate	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	0.215	0.87 pp	4318
Quintorius, Field Historian	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	0.205	-1.92 pp	12100
Blood Age General	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	0.186	-1.32 pp	14012
Make Your Mark	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	0.186	-0.75 pp	8081
Rise of Extus	Orzhov | Silverquill Pledgemage / Guiding Voice	0.178	0.57 pp	23288

7 Best Draft Priorities

Card	Best cluster	Pick score	Draft win lift	Rarity
Igneous Inspiration	Izzet | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	10.0 / 10	3.36 pp	uncommon
Quandrix Cultivator	Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	10.0 / 10	2.29 pp	uncommon
Expressive Iteration	Izzet | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	10.0 / 10	1.89 pp	uncommon
Killian, Ink Duelist	Orzhov | Silverquill Pledgemage / Guiding Voice	10.0 / 10	2.01 pp	uncommon
Bury in Books	Izzet | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	9.9 / 10	1.43 pp	common

Card	Best cluster	Pick score	Draft win lift	Rarity
Professor of Symbology	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	10.0 / 10	2.67 pp	uncommon
Multiple Choice	Izzet | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	9.9 / 10	5.25 pp	rare
Heated Debate	Izzet | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	9.8 / 10	1.26 pp	common
Closing Statement	Orzhov | Silverquill Pledgemage / Guiding Voice	9.9 / 10	1.98 pp	uncommon
Lorehold Command	Boros Spirits | Illustrious Historian / Lorehold Pledgemage	10.0 / 10	3.07 pp	rare
Shock	Izzet | Prismari Pledgemage / Elemental Masterpiece	9.7 / 10	2.02 pp	common
Professor of Zoomancy	Simic | Eureka Moment / Field Trip	10.0 / 10	1.48 pp	common

8 Verified Synergy Pairs

Every pair below passed a pair-interaction test on games-in-hand data, stratified by game length and play/draw, with Benjamini–Hochberg false-discovery control across all pairs tested in its archetype. λ is the interaction log-odds, shown as the change in the odds of winning when both cards are drawn, with its 95% confidence interval. Across all archetypes, 21 pairs are verified ($q \leq 0.10$) and 22 tentative ($q \leq 0.25$, marked †).

Pair	Archetype	Odds	95% CI	q	Pair WR	Games
Quintorius, Field Historian + Tome Shredder	Boros Spirits	+25%	[+14, +37]%	0.001	54.39%	3,278
Killian, Ink Duelist + Rise of Extus	Orzhov	+20%	[+10, +29]%	0.002	65.04%	4,565
Arcane Subtraction + Quandrix Pledgemage	Simic	+14%	[+7, +21]%	0.005	59.80%	8,130
Pigment Storm + Prismari Pledgemage	Izzet	+12%	[+6, +18]%	0.015	58.57%	12,520
Academic Dispute + Prismari Pledgemage	Izzet	+16%	[+7, +24]%	0.017	58.63%	6,154
Quintorius, Field Historian + Stonerise Spirit	Boros Spirits	+21%	[+9, +33]%	0.019	54.50%	2,622
Field Trip + Serpentine Curve	Simic	+12%	[+5, +19]%	0.028	58.63%	8,813

Pair	Archetype	Odds	95% CI	q	Pair WR	Games
Blood Researcher + Overgrown Arch	Golgari	+16%	[+7, +26]%	0.033	55.83%	4,890
Dina, Soul Steeper + Pest Summoning	Golgari	+16%	[+7, +26]%	0.033	54.82%	4,818
Devouring Tendrils + Witherbloom Pledgemage	Golgari	+18%	[+7, +31]%	0.046	59.65%	2,714
Blood Age General + Make Your Mark	Boros Spirits	+20%	[+8, +35]%	0.065	54.16%	1,837
Exhilarating Elocution + Killian, Ink Duelist	Orzhov	+18%	[+6, +30]%	0.066	58.06%	2,408
Arrogant Poet + Spiteful Squad	Orzhov	+12%	[+4, +20]%	0.066	54.21%	5,586
Elemental Masterpiece + Mizzix's Mastery	Izzet	+34%	[+12, +60]%	0.066	72.38%	1,115
Blade Historian + Pillardrop Rescuer	Boros Spirits	+32%	[+11, +58]%	0.075	63.78%	693
Professor's Warning + Sedgemoor Witch	Orzhov	+44%	[+12, +84]%	0.090	70.16%	372
Bury in Books + Quandrix Pledgemage	Simic	+9%	[+3, +16]%	0.095	60.72%	11,220
Fuming Effigy + Stonerise Spirit	Boros Spirits	+17%	[+6, +30]%	0.099	53.24%	2,083
Heated Debate + Tome Shredder	Boros Spirits	+13%	[+4, +23]%	0.099	56.70%	4,485
Frost Trickster + Illustrious Historian	Izzet	+12%	[+4, +21]%	0.099	56.54%	4,682
Combat Professor + Infuriate	Boros Spirits	+24%	[+7, +43]%	0.100	60.00%	1,135
Bayou Groff + Unwilling Ingredient	Golgari	+13%	[+4, +22]%	0.108†	52.01%	4,713
Clever Lumimancer + Study Break	Orzhov	+25%	[+6, +46]%	0.131†	56.92%	982
Codie, Vociferous Codex + Serpentine Curve	Izzet	+21%	[+6, +39]%	0.142†	60.62%	1,539

9 Anti-Synergies Worth Respecting

Pairs whose interaction is significantly negative ($q \leq 0.10$): they win less often when drawn together than their separate effects predict.

Pair	Archetype	Odds	95% CI	Pair WR	Games
Mizzix's Mastery + Tome Shredder	Izzet	-48%	[-62, -29]%	53.59%	181
Blot Out the Sky + Specter of the Fens	Orzhov	-38%	[-53, -19]%	60.14%	276
Igneous Inspiration + Lorehold Command	Boros Spirits	-35%	[-47, -22]%	62.97%	586
Spectacle Mage + Velomachus Lorehold	Izzet	-31%	[-45, -13]%	61.22%	490

Pair	Archetype	Odds	95% CI	Pair WR	Games
Professor of Symbology + Sedgemoor Witch	Orzhov	-30%	[-45, -12]%	61.90%	399
Bookwurm + Elemental Masterpiece	Simic	-25%	[-33, -15]%	57.06%	1,416
Blade Historian + Guiding Voice	Boros Spirits	-25%	[-36, -12]%	59.47%	987
Fortifying Draught + Springmane Cervin	Golgari	-25%	[-35, -12]%	47.47%	889
Expressive Iteration + Pop Quiz	Izzet	-21%	[-27, -16]%	57.83%	6,012
Pillardrop Rescuer + Returned Pastcaller	Boros Spirits	-21%	[-28, -12]%	52.02%	2,274

10 Bottom-Line Reading

This report treats the format as a deck ecosystem rather than a flat card ranking. Each archetype is described first by its core: the cards that are played in most of its decks, characteristic of it and connected to the rest of the deck. Bombs are listed separately because they win on their own and are worth taking (and often splashing) whatever the shell. Synergy claims are deliberately conservative: only pairs that survive a false-discovery-controlled interaction test are reported, with their effect size and confidence interval, so the short pair list is a feature of honest statistics rather than a lack of interplay between the cards.